

Destruction of the Soleil Royal
The French ships *Soleil Royal*, *Triomphant*, and *Admirable* are set on fire by English fireships at Cherbourg. Only one crew member on board the French flagship *Soleil Royal* survived the raid.

WAR OF THE LEAGUE OF AUGSBURG



BARFLEUR AND LA HOGUE

Date	May 29–June 4, 1692
Location	Off northern France
Result	Anglo-Dutch victory

COMBATANTS

ENGLAND AND DUTCH REPUBLIC	FRANCE

COMMANDERS

Edward Russell	Anne Hilarion de Tourville

FORCES

Ships: 82 ships of the line	**Ships:** 44 ships of the line

LOSSES

Ships: none	**Ships:** 15

BARFLEUR AND LA HOGUE

Encouraged by the French victory over the English and Dutch fleets at Beachy Head in 1690, French King Louis XIV planned an invasion of England in 1692 to reinstate the deposed King James II. Admiral de Tourville was to concentrate the French fleet at Brest, then sail on to Le Havre where French and Jacobite soldiers would embark in transports to be escorted across the Channel.

The project was from the outset plagued by delays. Originally planned for April, it had to be postponed because the transports were not ready in time. Even with an extra month, the French Mediterranean fleet, held up by bad weather, never arrived to join Tourville, who also had to sail without 20 of his own ships for lack of crews to man them. His fleet was thus woefully inadequate to confront the combined forces of the English and Dutch, who had been given ample time to gather in the Channel.

Tourville sighted the allied fleet off Cape Barfleur on the morning of May 29. Although it was twice his strength, he opted to give battle, perhaps hoping that English captains of Jacobite sympathies would change sides. None did. Holding the weather gage, Tourville no doubt hoped to exploit skilful seamanship and gunnery to inflict damage on a superior force and disengage at will.



Fireships at La Hogue
This Dutch delftware plaque depicts French sailors at La Hogue escaping from their burning ships, all 12 of which were destroyed.

BROADSIDES AND FIRESHIPS

Tourville laid his center, including his superb flagship *Soleil Royal*, alongside the allied center and a brutal exchange of broadsides began. The French van avoided envelopment by the Dutch ships of the allied van by continually giving way until at right-angles to the center. Tourville's attempt to control the battle was undermined by the caprice of the wind, which first shifted to deny him the advantage, and then dropped altogether. In a flat calm, ships of the line maneuvered under tow from their boats, sailors straining at the oars, or were carried by the tide if they opted not to anchor. The French center, unable to disengage, heroically fought a prolonged gunnery duel against the odds, while the allied rear strove to bring them under fire from both sides.

Fighting continued in an increasingly confused mêlée after nightfall. The English sailed fireships toward the enemy on the tide but the French coped with them efficiently. Exhaustion brought the battle to an end around 10:00 p.m.

Both sides suffered heavy casualties, but no ship was sunk or taken. If the French had escaped the following day, they could have celebrated a fine performance against a superior force. But too long was spent trying to save the crippled *Soleil Royal* and it was evening before Tourville ordered a general flight. Twenty-two ships used local knowledge to navigate a dangerous channel past Alderney to safety. Several escaped further afield, including two ships that took the Armada route around the north of Scotland. But 15 ships did not escape. The *Soleil Royal* and two others were beached at Cherbourg, where the English destroyed them with fireships. The rest beached at La Hogue. Despite the presence of shore batteries, the English attacked with long boats and fireships, and burned them all. The invasion plans were abandoned.

